

A photograph of tennis player Martin Landaluce in action on a blue court. He is wearing a white t-shirt with a Red Bull logo and a green wristband. He is holding a green tennis racket and looking towards the camera.

No. 67

MARTIN LANDALUCE

Only a tennis clairvoyant could have predicted that a Spaniard not named Alcaraz would make the quarterfinals in Carlitos' section of the draw at the Miami Open. Even more improbably, it was a 20-year-old qualifier ranked No. 151.

The lanky, 6'3" Landaluce had not qualified at any of the four ATP Tour-level events this year and had endured a mediocre 4-4 record on the 'minor-league' Challenger circuit. Suddenly, in Miami, his high-powered game clicked, and he won three qualifying matches

to gain momentum and confidence.

After going 0-4 against top-50 opponents, Landaluce whipped three in his stunning breakthrough tournament — No. 18 Luciano Darderi 6-3, 6-7(4), 6-4, No. 15 Karen Khachanov 6-3, 7-6(2), and Sebastian Korda 2-6, 7-6(6), 6-4, saving a match point. It took razor-sharp eventual finalist Jiri Lehecka to end his superb run, 7-6(1), 7-5.

Landaluce, whose ranking shot up to a career-high No. 106, believes the best is yet to come. "For sure, I think I'm playing at a really high level," said Landaluce. "I think I belong here for sure. If I keep playing like this, keep improving everything, I think I'm going to do big things."

Prediction: Quarterfinals



Bonus quarterfinal pick

Novak Djokovic, No. 5

Now 39 and with specks of grey in his hair, Novak Djokovic evoked memories of his halcyon days at two Majors this year. The sentimental favourite as the ageing champion, he upset Sinner 3-6, 6-3, 4-6, 6-4, 6-4 in the Australian Open semifinals. At Wimbledon, Djokovic outlasted No. 4 Felix Auger-Aliassime, 14 years his junior, 7-6, 3-6, 6-3, 6-7, 7-6, in the longest quarterfinal — 5 hours, 15 minutes — in the tournament's history.

In Djokovic's only match since the Wimbledon semifinal against Sinner, Thiago Agustin Tirante, a rocket-serving Argentine, defeated the legend, who struggled physically in the heat, 2-6, 6-4, 6-4 at Cincinnati. The US Open will likely be his last Major.

Before Taylor Fritz's 2026 Wimbledon quarterfinal against Zverev, whom Fritz had beaten in their previous seven meetings, Courier said, "For Fritz, this may be his last chance [to win a Major]. The winner will be favoured against the winner of the Cobolli-[Arthur] Fery quarterfinal." Hampered by a sore knee that impaired his movement, Fritz was overpowered by Zverev 6-4, 6-4, 6-2.

Two weeks later, Taylor rebounded to win the Mubadala DC Open, defeating Jodar and compatriot Brandon Nakashima. Three stats will likely determine how far Fritz advances at the US Open. In the past 12 months, the 6'5" Fritz has won a terrific 90 per cent of his service games thanks in part to his 640 aces, offset by only 75 double faults. On the debit side, he's won only a terrible 13 per cent of his return games this year. The good news is that Fritz ranks No. 5 in percentage of tiebreaks won, at 67.4 per cent.

Prediction: Quarterfinals

No. 9

TAYLOR FRITZ

